CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

OPTOMETRIST IN THE AI ERA

Doctor of eyes: primary care, a doctorate — and a practice you can actually own.

★ TL;DR — Around $130K median after 4+ years: an OD doctorate, national boards and a state license. The catch: doctoral debt and a retail-heavy entry market — ownership is the prize, not the starting line. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

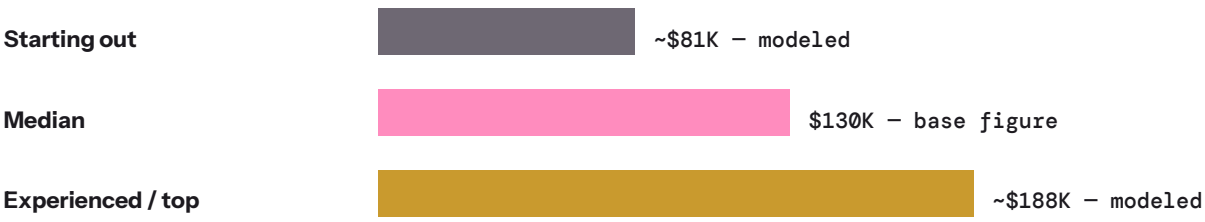
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$130K · TRAINING 4+ years · AI RISK LOW · STATE LICENSE

- A true doctoring profession with unusual ownership economics — practices are buyable businesses.
- Scope keeps expanding state by state (injections, lasers in some), growing the clinical ceiling.
- AI screens retinas; the comprehensive exam, diagnosis and patient relationship stay with the doctor.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Optometrist is a ~$130K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A OPTOMETRIST ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Run comprehensive eye exams: refraction, eye health, disease screening
- ✓ Diagnose and manage conditions like glaucoma, infections and diabetic eye changes
- ✓ Prescribe glasses, contacts and medications within your state scope
- ✓ Refer surgical and systemic cases; co-manage with ophthalmology and primary care

Think: the family doctor of the visual system — gatekeeper, diagnostician and shopkeeper in one white coat.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
AI refracting aids, retinal-image screening and automated charting speed the routine exam. Screening software flags disease; it doesn't own the diagnosis or the patient.	The exam dialogue: probing symptoms, weighing history, deciding what a shadow means. Patients buy judgment and a relationship, not a printout.

⚠ **The debt-to-median math only sings if you eventually move toward ownership or a strong specialty niche. A lifetime of high-volume retail exams is the outcome to plan against.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Daytime clinic hours — rare among doctorates ✓ Long-term patient relationships; families return for decades ✓ A real path to owning a profitable local practice	✗ 4+ years of doctoral tuition before earning ✗ Retail settings can squeeze exam times hard ✗ Repetitive refractions on high-volume days

Good fit? Science-strong, patient and business-curious — you can see yourself owning the practice someday.
Bad fit? You want earnings before your late twenties or hate the idea of retail-based healthcare.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — DEGREE, THEN THE OD DOCTORATE	DOOR B — COMBINED / ACCELERATED TRACKS
Undergraduate degree with science prerequisites, strong OAT score, then a 4-year Doctor of Optometry program with clinical rotations. Pass the national board exams and get your state license to practice.	Some universities offer combined bachelor's + OD tracks that shorten the total runway. You commit as an undergrad and must hold the required GPA — faster and sometimes cheaper, with less flexibility.

Smart move: Work as an optometric technician during undergrad — you'll learn the exam flow money can't teach and your OD applications will read differently.
Where you land after: Optometrist → specialty niches (pediatrics, low vision, ocular disease), partnership — or owning your own practice outright.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
RUN THE	BUILD THE	APPLY TO	COMPLETE THE	BOARDS, THEN	TAKE THE

STEP 1 — Run the long-game math

FREE · TODAY

- Compare OD programs by total cost and board pass rates.
- Read your state's optometry license and scope rules carefully — they vary a lot.

STEP 2 — Build the undergraduate base

YEARS · FOUNDATION

- Bachelor's with biology, chemistry, physics and math prerequisites.
- Shadow optometrists in private practice and retail settings — compare honestly.

STEP 3 — Apply to OD programs

APPLICATION SEASON

- Prepare for and take the OAT admission test.
- Apply broadly; weigh rotation quality and ownership culture of graduates.

STEP 4 — Complete the doctorate

4+ YEARS TOTAL RUNWAY

- Coursework plus clinical rotations across primary care and specialties.
- Choose final rotations in the setting you want to practice in.

STEP 5 — Boards, then the state license

EXAM FEES · AFTER GRADUATION

- Pass all parts of the national board exams (NBEO).
- Apply for and receive your state optometry license — required to practice.

STEP 6 — Take the first associate role

JOB HUNT · 2-6 WEEKS

- Compare associate offers by mentorship and path to partnership, not just salary.
- Decide early whether ownership is your direction; it shapes every later choice.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: map OD programs and total debt against the ~$130K median; read your state license rules.
- □ Days 1–30: start prerequisite enrollment; book shadowing days at two practices.
- □ Days 31–60: prerequisites underway; optometry tech/assistant job applications out.
- □ Days 61–90: target school list set; OAT exam timeline drafted.
- □ Day 90: the doctoral pipeline is structured — prereqs, shadowing and target schools moving.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **CLEAR VISION, LONG GAME.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.